



English Idioms

A Comprehensive Reference Guide

22 Essential Expressions

With Meanings & Examples

English Idioms Reference Guide

This guide presents 22 common English idioms with their meanings and example sentences to help you understand and use them correctly in everyday conversation.

1 Die in harness

Meaning: Die while still working, before retirement.

Example: He died in harness at age 65, still coming to the office every day.

2 Dog in the manger

Meaning: Someone who doesn't use something but also won't let others use it.

Example: Stop being a dog in the manger — if you don't want the toy, give it to your sister.

3 Flog a dead horse

Meaning: Waste time trying to fix something that's already over or impossible.

Example: Trying to convince him after he said no is flogging a dead horse.

4 Face the music

Meaning: Accept the bad results of your own actions.

Example: He cheated on the test, and now he has to face the music.

5 Go to the dogs

Meaning: Become much worse in quality or condition.

Example: This neighborhood has gone to the dogs — it's so dirty now.

6 Follow suit

Meaning: Do the same thing someone else just did.

Example: When one store lowered prices, the others quickly followed suit.

7 Hue and cry

Meaning: A loud public complaint or protest.

Example: There was a great hue and cry when the factory closed down.

8 Hit below the belt

Meaning: Say or do something unfair and cruel, especially using personal weakness.

Example: Bringing up his past mistakes during an argument is hitting below the belt.

9 By hook or by crook

Meaning: By any means necessary (good or bad).

Example: She will get that job by hook or by crook.

10 Beat about the bush

Meaning: Avoid saying something directly.

Example: Stop beating about the bush — just tell me what happened.

11 Burn the midnight oil

Meaning: Work late into the night.

Example: He burned the midnight oil studying for his exam.

12 Call a spade a spade

Meaning: Speak the truth directly, even if it's rude.

Example: She calls a spade a spade — if you're wrong, she'll tell you.

13 Cast pearls before swine

Meaning: Offer something valuable to someone who won't appreciate it.

Example: Giving him expensive wine is casting pearls before swine; he only likes cheap beer.

14 A white elephant

Meaning: Something expensive to keep or maintain.

Example: This huge old house became a white elephant for us.

15 A maiden speech

Meaning: The very first speech someone gives.

Example: Her maiden speech in parliament was nervous but honest.

16 A wild goose chase

Meaning: A search or effort that is completely useless and a waste of time.

Example: Trying to find that lost earring in the park was a wild goose chase.

17 At the eleventh hour

Meaning: At the last possible moment.

Example: He finished his homework at the eleventh hour.

18 At daggers drawn

Meaning: Very angry with each other; ready to fight.

Example: The two brothers are at daggers drawn over their father's property.

19 A fair weather friend

Meaning: Someone who is your friend only when things are going well.

Example: As soon as I lost my job, my fair weather friends disappeared.

20 An axe to grind

Meaning: A selfish reason for doing or saying something.

Example: His complaint wasn't fair — he had an axe to grind.

21 A rolling stone

Meaning: A person who keeps moving and never settles down.

Example: After college, he became a rolling stone and lived in ten different cities.

22 Bury the hatchet

Meaning: Stop fighting and make peace.

Example: They argued for years but finally buried the hatchet.

Quick Summary Cheat Sheet

Idiom	Simple Meaning
Die in harness	Die while working
Dog in the manger	Selfish with unused things
Flog a dead horse	Waste time on a lost cause
Face the music	Accept bad consequences
Go to the dogs	Become much worse
Follow suit	Copy someone's action
Hue and cry	Loud public complaint
Hit below the belt	Fight unfairly or cruelly
By hook or by crook	By any means necessary
Beat about the bush	Avoid the main point
Burn the midnight oil	Work late at night
Call a spade a spade	Speak blunt truth
Cast pearls before swine	Give valuables to those who don't care
A white elephant	Too expensive to keep
A maiden speech	First speech
A wild goose chase	Useless search
At the eleventh hour	Last possible moment
At daggers drawn	Very hostile

A fair weather friend	Friend only in good times
An axe to grind	Hidden selfish motive
A rolling stone	Never settles down
Bury the hatchet	Make peace